

Philosophy

# #7:Human nature


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# Critical questions

- What is human nature?
- What makes to be human?
- What is our real self?

# Class Learning Objective

1. Critically evaluate the rationalistic versions of the Traditional Western view of human nature.
2. Explain how Darwinism challenged these views.
3. Explain why dualism is so influential as a view of human nature, even though it leads to mind-body problem.
4. Explain & critically evaluate the way materialism identity theory, behaviorism & new dualism  tries to solve the mind-body problem

## What is the self?

- **Plato**: an eternal soul, which is from the true world ('the world of forms').
- **Descartes**: a separate thing called a 'mind' which interacts with the body.
- **Hume**: nothing but a bundle of perceptions.
- **Dawkins**: an illusion created by the brain.
- **Locke**: continued consciousness.
- **Aristotle**: the organisation of rational thought and irrational desires.

Overview on human nature:

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1) humans have an ego, I, or self that is conscious or rational

2) this self (spiritual or immaterial entity) is distinct from yet related to the body (physical or material entity) and can survive the death of the body

3) this self has continuity or identity over time

4) this self exists independently or separate from other people or things

# Overview

How do one's views of human nature influence one's…

– relationships with others?

– relationship to the universe?

– understanding of GOD and afterlife?



# Who am I

## What is real self ?

- I am directly to me the given integrity of my individual life. I perceive myself as the  center of my consciousness, as someone who owns my thoughts, desires, experiences.
- At the same time, I am the unity of my biography; this is what guarantees my self-identity.
- Finally, I am what controls my body; it is the instance that ensures the free adoption of my decisions and is responsible for their implementation and consequences.

Thought experiment

A face may appear entirely different from a distance and completely different  from close up
Your concept of the self may also shift after philosophical investigation

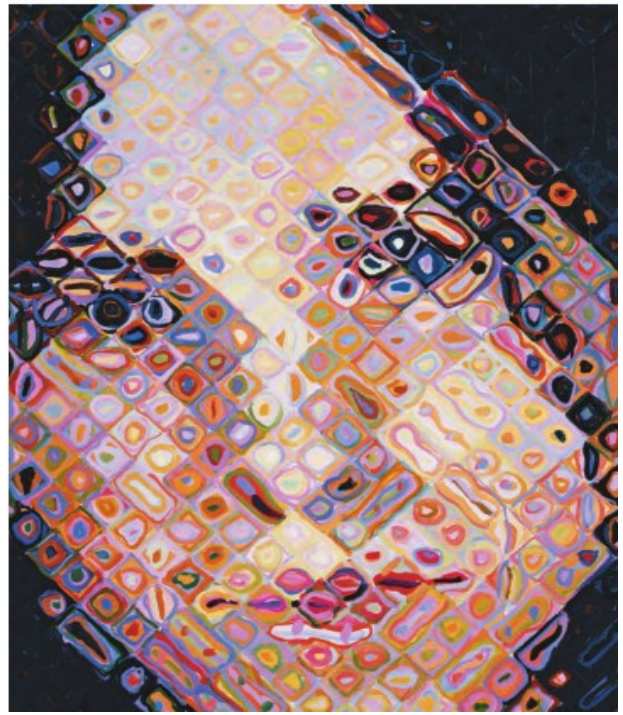


Image Reference:
Velasquez, M. (2005). *Philosophy: A Text with Readings* (9th ed.). Belmont, CA: Wadsworth.

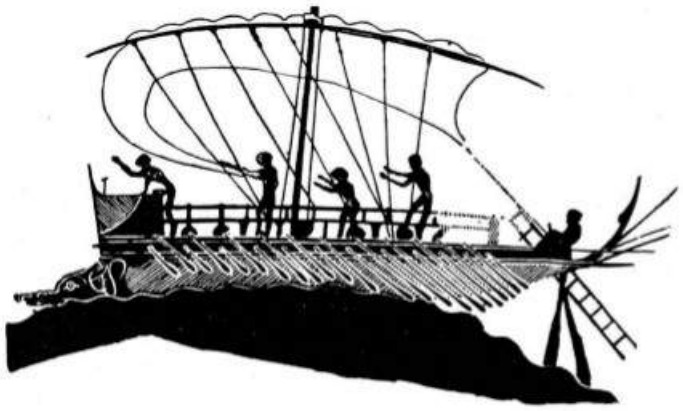




- In what sense does the self change if body undergoes changes?
- Does the self remains the same even if body changes?

Image Reference: Velasquez, M. (2005). *Philosophy: A Text with Readings* (9th ed.). Belmont, CA: Wadsworth.

# Thought experiment



The Ship of Theseus

## Personal Identity

What ensures my survival over time?

- The Bodily Criterion
- The Brain Criterion
- The Psychological Criterion

John Locke



# Man is selfish by nature or selfless.

- Hobbes: Humans are selfish by nature and must be controlled.
- Locke: Humans are rational by nature, and can by-and-large control themselves.
- Rousseau: Humans are good and compassionate by nature, but can be corrupted by civilization.
- Kant: Humans are selfish by nature, but can control themselves through rational, universalized thinking.
- Rawls: Humans are selfish by nature, and the Social Contract must be made attractive by appealing to everyone's self-interest.

The soul works best when the 'reason' is in charge

Our appetite can lead us to do unhelpful things



We need spirit (or will) to make us determined to do the right thing

A good person = one whose soul is balanced with reason at the helm

# 1.Rationalist view

Human self is rational mind

# 1. Rationalist View of Human Nature:

- Neither understood human beings as essentially egoistic or self-interested.
- Rationalism emphasizes the role of reason and intellect in defining human nature.
- Rationalists argue that human nature is characterized by rationality and the capacity for logical thought. This perspective often intersects with classical Western views that emphasize reason as the defining feature of humanity.
- **Socrates** said that the Reason is the most distinctive capacity of human beings.
- **Plato** thought that human nature has three parts reason, which pursues knowledge of immaterial rational soul, when torn between its bodily desires and its aggressive impulses .
- **Aristotle** said that the purpose of humans is to use their reason to think and to control desires and aggressions.
- **They all believed reason is the most distinctive capacity of human beings**.
- The purpose of humans is to use their reason to think and to control desires and aggressions.

According to this view humans are made in the image of God. The ability to love is the characteristic of a human being. All humans are capable of this ability regardless of their level of rationality.

Loving, as well as serving, God is of upmost importance.

St. Augustine emphasized the nature of the will. We have the ability to choose between good or evil.

# 2.Religious view

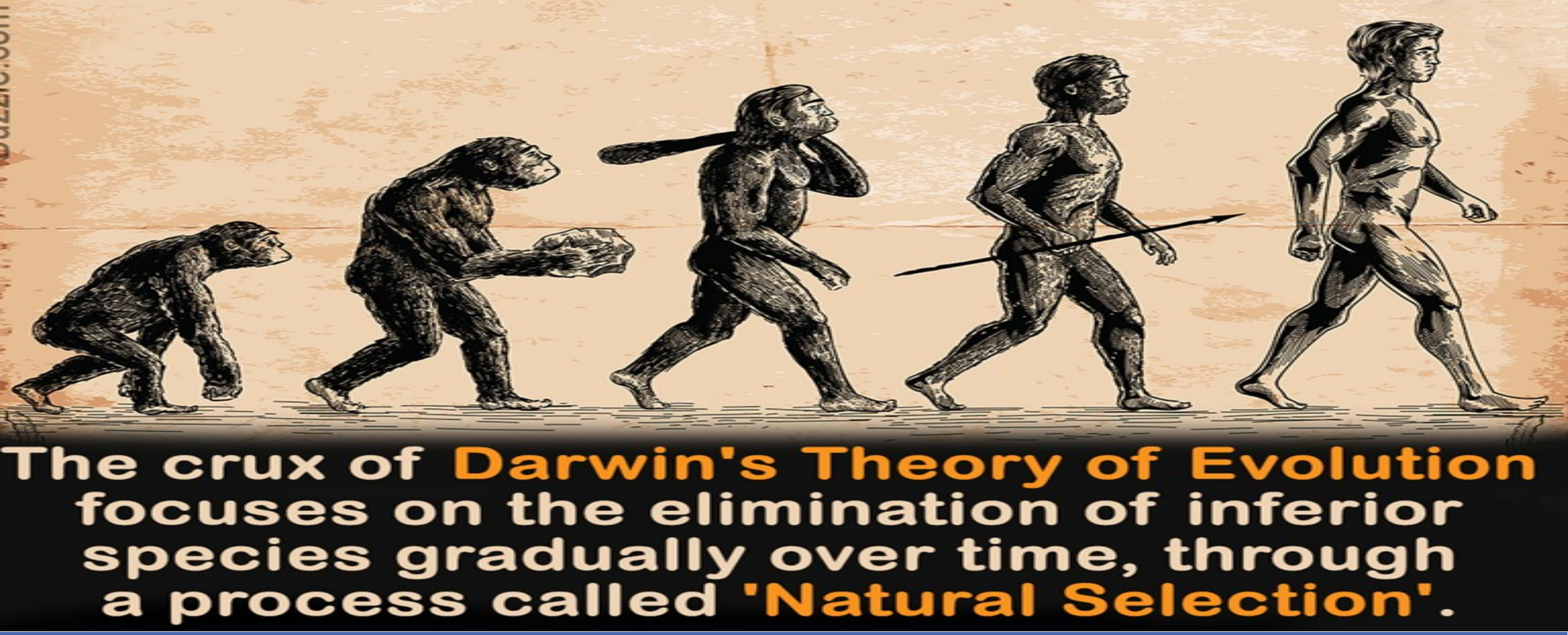
Human self is pure soul

# 2. Religious View of Human Nature:

- Soul is governed the reason, emotion and  desires with divine pure soul.
- The soul can do this only if it controls its bodily desires and trains its aggressive impulses so that both obey reason.
- Humans are made in the image of God, who has endowed them with rational self-consciousness and an ability to love.
- The soul can do this only if it controls its bodily desires and trains its aggressive impulses so that both obey reason.
- The purpose of humans is to achieve happiness by using their reason to know God.

The religious perspective on human nature often emphasizes the belief that humans are created in the image of God, endowed with free will, and possess an inherent moral capacity.

This view includes the idea of humans as beings with a soul, moral agency, and a purpose given by a divine creator.



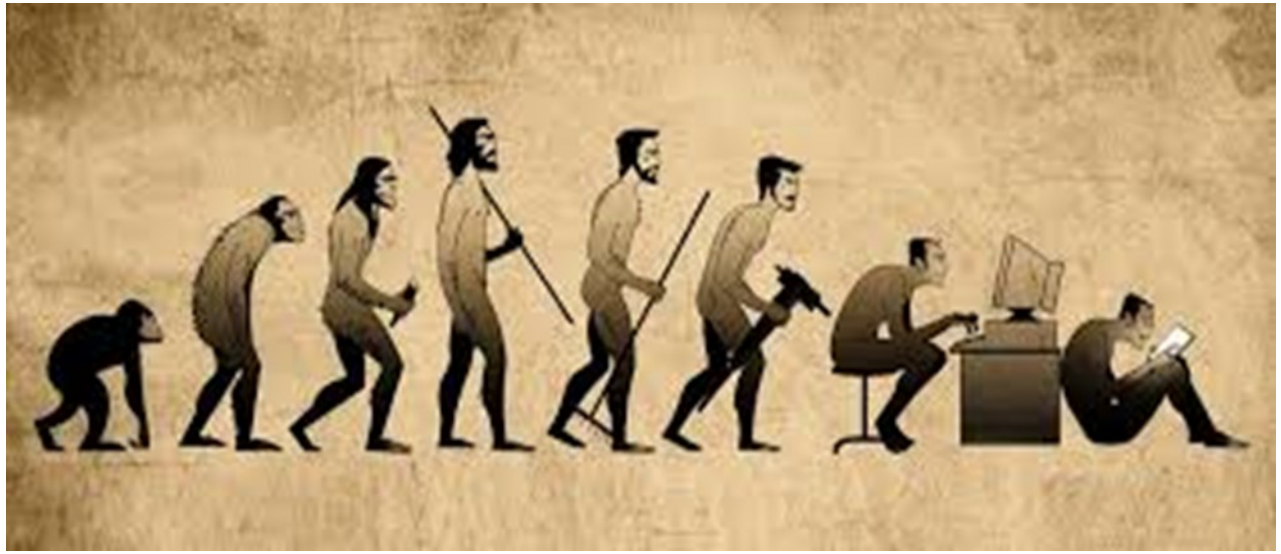

# 3.Evolutionary view

Human self is evolutionary

# Three Key Ideas

Charles Darwin (1809-1882) proposed three important ideas:

1. Natural Variation : reproduction
2. Struggle for Existence : competition for food
3. Natural Selection : adaptation



# Evidence for Darwin's theory

Darwin offered four distinct bodies of evidence in favor of evolution:

1. The existence of similar species (like monkeys and gorillas) with shared common characteristics.

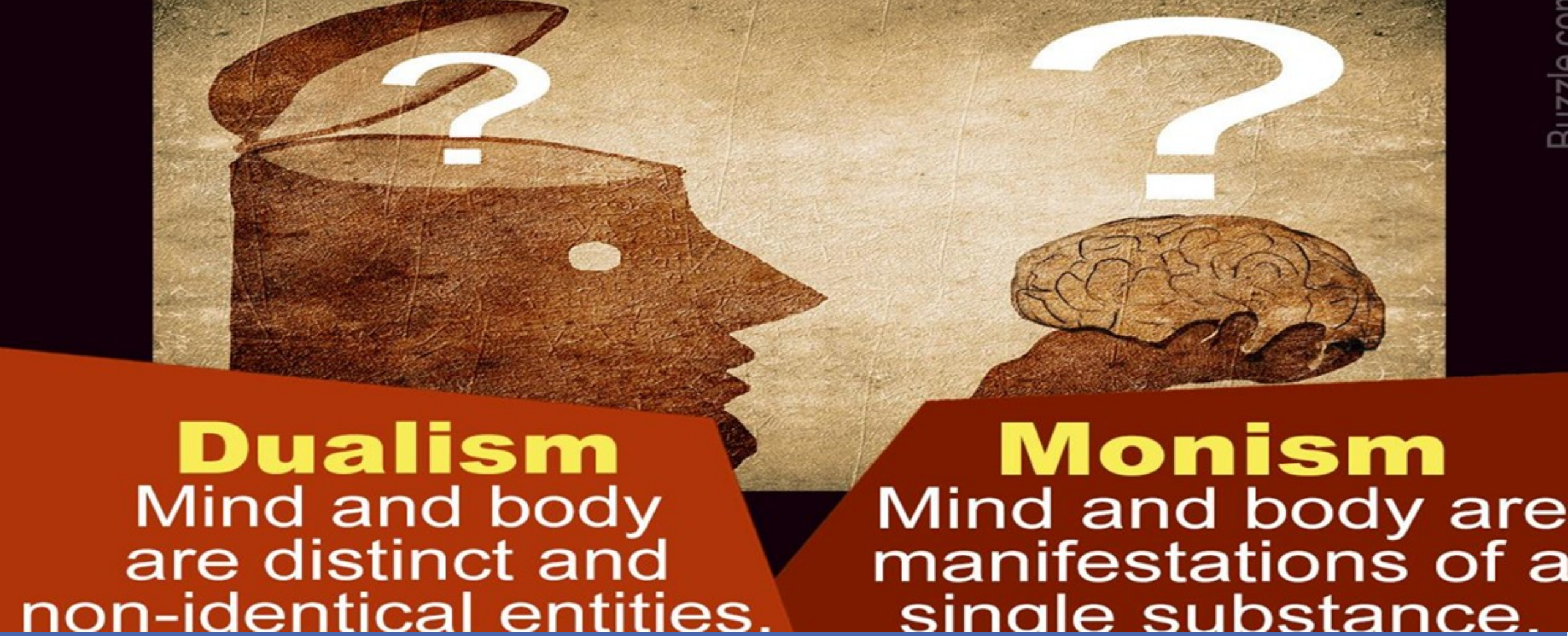
2. The geographically distribution of species over the face of the earth.

3. The similarity of bone structures, embryonic developments, and useless rudimentary organs among contemporary living creatures.

4. The fossil record was best explained by his theory that species living today had descended from different earlier species.

# 3. Evolutionary view of human nature

- Human self as brain evolve biological to survive  interact with environment.
- Human self is doing struggle for self improvement for survival.
- That the ability of reason is a completely different kind of ability than any of the abilities other animals have.
- The notion that all species, including humans, arose in an evolutionary was a disturbing new thought for many people.
- That the ability of reason is a completely different kind of ability than any of the abilities other animals have.
- That humans are designed for a purpose so our Self is doing struggle for self improvement for survival.
- Origin of species in 1959 considered self as evolution for survival.




# 4.Dualistic view

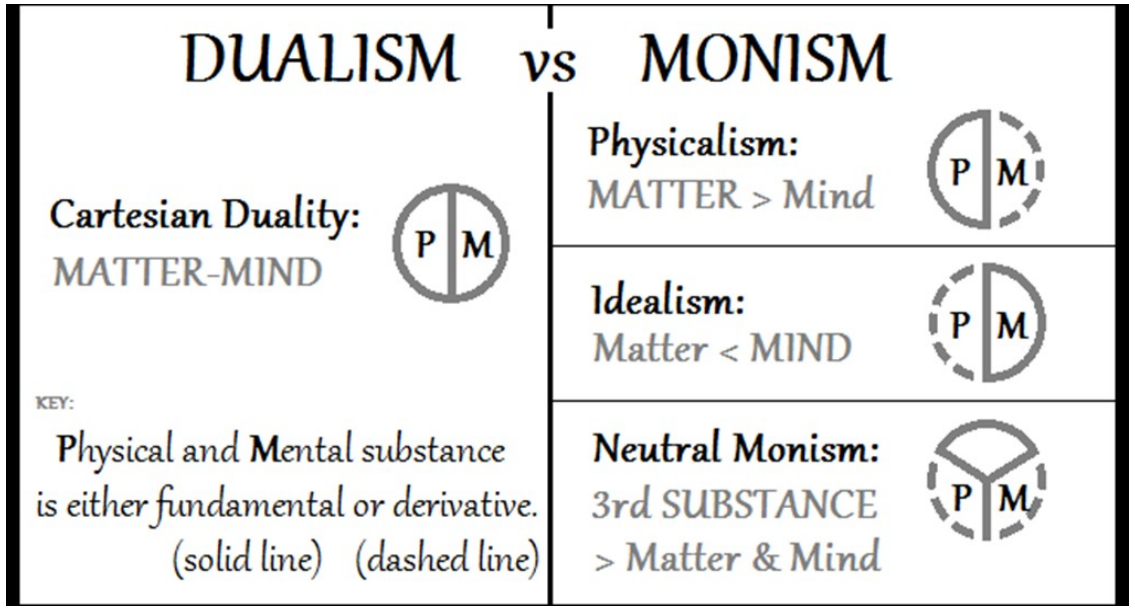
Mind-body problem

# 4. The Dualistic View:

- The most famous version of this perspective was developed by Rene Descartes.
- Descartes argued that the mind and body are two distinct things or substances that interact with one another.
- Dualism, especially Cartesian dualism, posits that human nature consists of two distinct substances: the mind (or soul) and the body.
- This view emphasizes the separation between mental and physical aspects of human nature.
- The human self is a rational self with reason and humans have an immaterial and immortal soul.
- Descartes' said that humans are immaterial thinking beings different from, but connected to, material bodies, immaterial minds can interact with material bodies.

# The Mind-Body Problem

- One philosophical theory of the mind-body relation is called dualism, the view that human beings are immaterial minds within material Bodies
- The most famous version of this perspective was developed by Rene Descartes
- Descartes argued that the mind and body are two distinct things or substances that interact with one another.



# I think therefore I am-Cogito Ergo sum

- The self is not a body—that is, it is not a physical thing.
- I cannot think of myself without thinking. So, thinking is necessary for the self; it is part of the essence.
- All humans, then, are selves that are immaterial, that are essentially conscious, and that can exist without the body, which is material and unconscious.

# Dualism: How do mind and body work ?

- Your mind and its properties, then, seem to be completely different from your body and its properties.

- Self is composed of two things

1. Material body
2. Immaterial mind or soul.

- Human are the boundary line of  spiritual and corporal nature-St. Aquinas

- Leibnitz said that mind and body interact with each other at parallel pre established harmonize order.

# Pre-established harmony-Leibniz

Gottfried Leibniz (1646–1716) addressed the question of interaction by arguing that mind and body run in parallel order, like two clocks that are synchronized so that they seem to be connected yet operate independently.

The mind and body were perfectly synchronized. What happens instead, he said, is that God steps in to synchronize the body and the mind.

# New dualism

There  are two kinds of substances—that is, entities or things—in the universe.

Consciousness  cannot conscious experience involves properties of an individual that are not entailed by the physical properties of that individual.

What  makes you the same self today that you were ten years ago is your body.



# 5.Materialistic view

Mans are machine

# 5. The Materialistic View:

- Materialism asserts that human nature is entirely physical and can be explained through the properties and processes of matter.
- According to materialists, mental states and consciousness are the result of physical interactions within the brain and body.
- Hobbes argues that what seem to be immaterial mental processes are really nothing more than physical processes.
- The materialist Hobbes said the mind could be reduced to the physical actions of a material body, so there is no need to believe that immaterial things exist.
- We must acknowledge that only material things exist. The explanations of mental activities in terms of physical processes.

# Hobbes : MAN IS MACHINE

For seeing life is but a motion of limbs, the beginning whereof is in some principal part within; why may we not say, that all automata (engines that move themselves by

springs and wheels as does a watch) have an artificial life?

For what is the heart, but a spring; and the nerves, but so many strings; and the joints, but so many wheels, giving motion to the whole body, such as was intended by the artificer?

Hobbes took the position that human beings, including their minds, were completely material.

Human mind are caused by sense experience which is resolvable into fundamental material particles.

# Reading text

**The philosopher way**

Chapter 3 : Identity, self and consciousness

3.2 who am I

3.3 Rationalist/Dualism

3.4 Consciousness

3.8 self is brain-Materialism

**Philosophy**

Chapter 2 : what is human nature

2.2 What is human nature

2.3 How do mind and body relate ?

# Philosophical review on film

What if consciousness could be transferred?

In the movie The Curious Case of Benjamin Button, the character played by Brad Pitt finds that his twelve-year-old personal identity is installed in the body of an adult version of himself—the kind of self-mobility that Locke suggests might be possible.



# Literature review on Human nature

